

events—called Ryze Mixers—are popular with the members of a particular group, and provide them the opportunity to meet people, and develop personal and professional relationships.

Different Strokes For Different Folks

The recently-launched beta versions of Yahoo! 360° (<http://360.yahoo.com/>) and Microsoft's Wallop (www.mywallop.com) are the new entrants in the social networking realm.

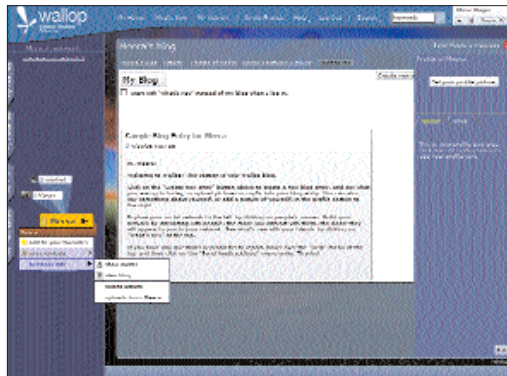
Both let you store and share pictures and music, and provide additional features such as blogs, and the facility to send instant messages via existing instant messenger clients such as MSN, Yahoo! or AOL Messenger. Yahoo! 360° also allows users to send personalised notes to their Yahoo! 360° contacts, which the latter can view on their home pages.

Wallop's Flash interface is groovier than the existing networks. Apart from providing a blogging tool and a music player, Wallop also lets users set up an RSS (Rich Site Summary or Really Simple Syndication) feed—RSS is an XML format for distribution of news headlines on the Internet.

RSS enables bloggers to share their latest entries and other news from across the Web.

Orkut's personalised message boards are popular among its users, but Orkut has had serious issues with speed, with members complaining that pages “take forever” to load. [See box below]

Ryze (www.ryze.com) and LinkedIn (www.linkedin.com) are more serious business



Wallop's 'flashy' interface offers various add-ons

Digit Forum Votes For Yahoo! Groups

We asked our forum members what they thought of online communities. Yahoo! Groups wins hands down, polling 44 per cent of the votes—out of, umm, nine responses! Here's what some of our members have to say.

Enoonmai: “I've been using Ryze for quite some time now, and find it very good. I signed up for Yahoo! 360° recently. I doubt if Yahoo! 360 can take off as a popular business networking site, but it might do quite well with youngsters and those into semi-casual social networking.”

Tuxian: “Well, Ryze is great. You develop contacts with a lot of important people. Orkut sucks when it comes to speed... (and is) not that attractive. Yahoo! 360° still needs to be evaluated...”

Deep: “I was on Orkut for a while. In the beginning, I found it pretty cool... but that's it. No one even cared to reply to messages after that... so it was

kind of bad. People signed up there in all the excitement, but no one cared to keep in touch. It's also way too slow.”

Din: “My college friends are all in different parts of the world now, but we're connected through mailing lists and Yahoo! Groups.”

Link to Discussion Thread: <http://snipurl.com/dzn4>



LinkedIn is popular among top business executives

networking communities. With a clean, functional interface, Ryze lets you import contacts from your e-mail client. Members can add and remove contacts as they like, and regulate the amount of information that is disclosed to each contact.

LinkedIn is a ‘white-collar’ business networking community, targeting executives at the CEO/CTO level. It enables companies find suitable candidates, clients, partners and industry experts. Members can invite and apply for job offers listed on the site. Again, membership and referral is strictly by invitation only.

Friendster (www.friendster.com), a global networking community, categorises members by personal details and geographic location. It claims a membership of nearly over 13 million.

Tribe (www.tribe.net) is a compilation of thousands of moderated discussion threads on specific topics, such as, cinema, music, and news. You can post your profile and be part of numerous ‘tribes’, or special-interest groups.

Hi5 (www.hi5.com) is another popular networking site. Hi5 also enables photo sharing and blogging, along with RSS feeds, and a message board.

Almost all these networking sites are still in the beta or test stage, and need to resolve security and speed issues. By ensuring that members get to decide whom to invite into their networks, these sites attempt to avoid the entry of online marketers and spam, to which several Yahoo! Groups fall prey.

Six Degrees Of Separation

Social networks attempt to capitalise on the ‘Six Degrees of Separation’ theory, according to which, each human being is separated from another by no more than six degrees, or six friends’ friends (or six clicks, in case of the Internet!)

Whether social networks help you find a good companion, soul mate, life partner or business associate depends largely on your attitude towards online communities: be patient, don't expect miracles, and be honest while communicating with your online buddies.

After all, as Baz Luhrmann said in the ‘Sunscreen Song’, “Your choices are half chance. So are everybody else's”. ■

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